# ABEL W. SUGEBO

Washington, DC | abelwabella@gmail.com
linkedin.com/in/abelwabella | abelsugebo.com

## SUMMARY

Trust and safety practitioner and influence operations analyst with 10+ years in information integrity, platform manipulation research, and digital rights. Founder of Ethiopia's first IFCN-accredited fact-checking platform and a certified DISARM analyst. Track record building OSINT investigations, content policy analysis, and cross-border threat research, including published research on coordinated abuse of automated content moderation and AI-generated propaganda. Native Amharic speaker with regional depth across the Horn of Africa and Red Sea information environment. Fully authorized to work in the United States.

## PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

**Executive Director and Founder**
Inform Africa / HaqCheck | Addis Ababa, Ethiopia and Remote | 2021 – Present

- Founded and lead Ethiopia's first International Fact-Checking Network (IFCN) accredited platform, directing open source intelligence (OSINT) investigations into disinformation, influence operations, and coordinated platform manipulation across the Horn of Africa and Red Sea information environment.
- Secured and maintain IFCN accreditation through annual external assessment covering methodology, transparency, funding disclosure, and corrections policy.
- Authored "When AI Moderation Becomes a Weapon: Ethiopia's Mass Reporting Crisis" (2026), an investigation documenting coordinated mass-reporting campaigns that weaponize automated content moderation to force takedowns of journalist and civil society accounts.
- Authored a DISARM case study of AI-generated propaganda linking Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam (GERD) narratives to "Assab" sea-access narratives (2025).
- Built and operationalized DISARM-based analytical workflows for classifying influence operation tactics, techniques, and procedures (TTPs), applied across an investigation series spanning elections, armed conflict, economic policy, and human rights.
- Built and managed a distributed team of up to 15 researchers, editors, and verification staff; own organizational budget, donor reporting, and strategy.
- Sustained continuous publication and staff safety through active armed conflict and repeated nationwide internet shutdowns.

**Ethiopia Country Researcher**
CIPESA (Collaboration on International ICT Policy for East and Southern Africa) | Remote | 2025 – 2026 | Consulting engagement

- Authored the Ethiopia country chapter of State of Internet Freedom in Africa for two consecutive editions, analyzing network disruptions, platform regulation, surveillance practice, and legal restrictions on digital expression.
- Delivered research to an external institution's methodology, peer review process, and publication deadlines.

**Managing Director**
Addis Zeybe | Addis Ababa, Ethiopia | 2018 – 2024 | Concurrent with Inform Africa from 2021

- Led editorial, operations, and strategy for an independent digital news organization of approximately 30 staff covering Ethiopian politics, armed conflict, and information integrity.
- Directed conflict-period coverage of disinformation and platform manipulation, establishing verification and sourcing standards applied across the newsroom.
- Managed editorial and operations staff with full ownership of the organizational budget and donor relationships through sustained political instability and regulatory pressure.

**Consultant, Media Resilience and Digital Safety**
Free Press Unlimited | Amsterdam, Netherlands (remote) | 2020 – 2022 | Concurrent with Addis Zeybe

- Advised on media resilience, information integrity, and digital safety programming for newsrooms and civil society organizations operating in high-risk and conflict-affected environments.
- Delivered assessments and training within an international NGO's program framework, reporting against defined deliverables and timelines.

**Fact-Checker**
PesaCheck | Nairobi, Kenya (remote) | 2020 – 2021 | Contract, concurrent with Addis Zeybe

- Investigated and debunked viral misinformation across East African information ecosystems using reverse image analysis, geolocation, account network mapping, and primary-source verification.
- Published to the editorial and methodological standards of Africa's largest fact-checking initiative.

**Editor**
Addis Fortune | Addis Ababa, Ethiopia | 2017 – 2018

- Edited business, economic, and public policy coverage for one of Ethiopia's leading English-language newspapers.

**Mechanical Engineer**
Ethiopian Airlines | Addis Ababa, Ethiopia | 2011 – 2014

- Technical systems and maintenance engineering in a safety-critical operating environment; quantitative foundation for later data-driven analytical work.

## SELECTED PUBLICATIONS AND RESEARCH

- "False in 2021, Asserted in 2026: Eritrean Troops and the Politics of Verification," Inform Africa, October 2026.
- "When AI Moderation Becomes a Weapon: Ethiopia's Mass Reporting Crisis," Inform Africa, March 2026.
- "DISARM Case Study: AI-Generated Propaganda Linking GERD Pride to 'Assab' Sea-Access Narratives," Inform Africa, December 2025.
- State of Internet Freedom in Africa, Ethiopia country chapter, CIPESA, 2025 and 2026.
- "Comprehensive Training Module for Advanced Fact-Checking Using OSINT Technologies," Inform Africa, December 2025.
- "Assessing the Impact of Disinformation on Current Ethiopian Economic Reform: A Social Media Analysis," Inform Africa, December 2024.
- "Measuring Government Responsiveness in Ethiopia: Implications for Countering Disinformation," Inform Africa, September 2023.
- "Annual Report 2022: War and Disinformation," Inform Africa, March 2023.
- "Disinformation Pathways and Effects," Inform Africa with CIPESA, August 2022.
- "Report on the 6th Ethiopian General Election and Human Rights Violations," Inform Africa, February 2022.
- Contributor, DISARM Framework documentation, data-knowledge-hub.com.

## SKILLS

**Trust and Safety:** content policy analysis and enforcement, coordinated inauthentic behavior (CIB) detection, platform manipulation analysis, content moderation systems, adversarial testing and red teaming, risk assessment and escalation

**Influence Operations:** DISARM framework (certified analyst), Foreign Information Manipulation and Interference (FIMI), TTP classification and attribution, narrative and network analysis, threat intelligence reporting, AI-generated propaganda analysis

**OSINT and Research:** open source intelligence collection, reverse image analysis, geolocation, account network mapping, fact-checking and verification methodology, qualitative and quantitative research design, OSINT training design and delivery

**Technical:** Python, SQL, Power BI, data analysis and visualization

**Languages:** Amharic (native), English (fluent)

## AWARDS AND RECOGNITION

- CPJ International Press Freedom Award, Committee to Protect Journalists, 2015
- TV5 Monde Prize, 2015
- Hellman-Hammett Grant, Human Rights Watch, 2015
- Martin Ennals Award for Human Rights Defenders, Finalist, 2016

## EDUCATION AND CERTIFICATION

B.S., Mechanical Engineering, Bahir Dar University, Ethiopia, 2005–2008

Certified DISARM Analyst

## LEADERSHIP AND AFFILIATIONS

Co-founder, Zone Nine, Ethiopia's first independent digital rights blogging collective

Member, Global Coalition for Tech Justice